

Session 5 Worksheet: Testing the Meaning - Theory A vs Theory B

CBT for OCD | Name: _____ Date: _____ Clinician: _____

Last session we found the meaning (appraisal) attached to the intrusive thought. Now we examine whether that meaning is true, and consider a kinder, more accurate alternative. A helpful CBT frame is Theory A vs Theory B: is the real problem the danger the OCD warns about, or is the problem that I am WORRIED about the danger?

A. The two theories

Theory A (what OCD says)	Theory B (an alternative)
The problem is: _____ (e.g. "I am dangerous / something bad will happen and it's my job to stop it").	The problem is: _____ (e.g. "I have OCD, which makes me worry I'm dangerous; the thoughts are not the truth").
If Theory A is true, what would I have to keep doing? (checking, avoiding, seeking reassurance, suppressing) _____	If Theory B is true, what should I do instead? (treat the thought as noise, drop the compulsions, live normally) _____

How much do I believe Theory A right now (0-100%)? _____

How much do I believe Theory B right now (0-100%)? _____

B. Examining the evidence for the appraisal

Evidence FOR the OCD meaning	Evidence AGAINST / another explanation

C. Helpful questions to challenge the appraisal

- Would I judge a friend / anyone else this harshly for having the same thought?
- Does having a thought make it true, or make me want it? What is the evidence?
- What would I tell someone I care about who had this exact thought?
- Has the feared outcome ever actually happened despite the thought? What really happened?
- Is demanding 100% certainty realistic - do people live with normal uncertainty?
- How much responsibility is truly mine? (see the pie below)

D. Responsibility pie

List every factor that would contribute to the feared outcome (chance, other people, circumstances, etc.), give each a % share, and assign yourself a slice LAST. Notice how small your true share usually is.

Contributing factor	% share

Contributing factor	% share
My actual share (fill in last)	

E. A more balanced, accurate thought

Write a fair, realistic response to the intrusive thought - not falsely reassuring, just accurate.

Re-rate belief in the OCD meaning now (0-100%): _____

Re-rate distress now (0-100): _____

Homework: when the intrusion appears, respond with Theory B and the balanced thought instead of doing a compulsion.